



ThinkCollege

NATIONAL COORDINATING CENTER

INSTITUTE FOR COMMUNITY INCLUSION, UMASS BOSTON

SUPPORTING FACULTY THROUGH PLANNING AND COMMUNICATION STRATEGIES FOR SUCCESS

Meg Grigal and Clare Papay
State of the Art on Inclusive Higher Education Conference
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Findings from a Qualitative Study

Taylor, Domin, Papay & Grigal (2021)



Faculty experiences teaching inclusive courses in TPSID programs



Eligibility: faculty had taught at least 3 students with ID in inclusive courses



Sample: 10 faculty (four part-time, five full-time, 1 recently retired)

7 colleges and universities

5 states

Average 13 years' experience teaching (range 1.5–35 years)



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Benefits



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Benefits to Students with ID



Social interactions with college peers



Opportunities to pursue topics of interest



Importance of having classmates listen to and value opinions



Development of greater independence and leadership

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“So often my sense is that in these inclusive situations, we’re looking at how it benefits the students with intellectual disabilities. And my interest in research, and from experience, I just see it the other way around: that they are really—their presence is benefiting the undergraduate students in many, many ways”

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Benefits to Typical Students and the Classroom Environment

- Increased student engagement in inclusive classrooms.
- Greater level of “enthusiasm” and a more “positive attitude”
- The willingness of students with ID to pose questions was an advantage for the entire classroom

“My daytime classes are inclusive, and then in the evenings, they’re not. So, it’s very obvious that the classes that are inclusive are...more dynamic, more engaged.”



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Broader Discussions

- Students with ID introduced a greater variety of experiences, perspectives, and ways of thinking into classroom discussions.
- Improved the learning experience of all students

“We’ve had some times where [students with ID] will bring up something or ask a question that really sparks a good discussion, which leads to the benefit to the traditional students”



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Benefits for college peers

- Peers gain skills in collaboration and communication from interacting with classmates with ID.

"It caused the team to have to work a little bit more creatively on how to integrate the [student with ID] into their team to give them a meaningful task, not just a filler task or a remedial task. They have to really think about, "Well, how will I give this student a meaningful role ... on the team?"

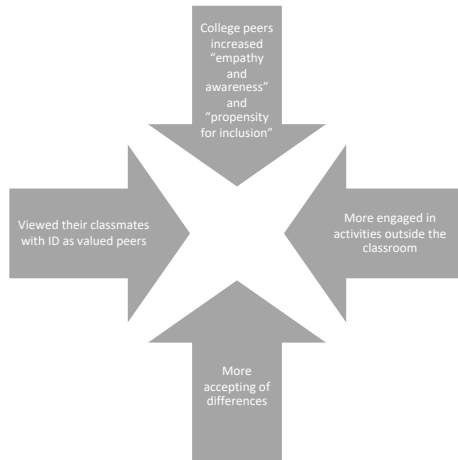


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Social-Emotional benefits



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So one of the first things
 I thought to myself was

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Benefits to Faculty

- Improving faculty teaching skills
- More able to respond to range range of student learning styles, educational experiences, and capabilities
- Led to increased confidence
- Led to reflection on existing practices and need for breaking down complex information

"I was nervous. But it really gave myself confidence that I can work with any type of student."

"If you're teaching for a really long time ... you can ... forget that there are different levels in that classroom. And these students are individuals; it's not just one big classroom."



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Challenges and Considerations



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*"I am never entirely clear what their goals are,
what their needs are."*



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Two levels of information

Student Information

- Relevant background
- Goals for the course
- Relevant longer-term goals
- Supports needed
- Communication strategies

Program information

- Where it is housed
- Who oversees it
- Overall goals
- Existing resources/information
- Who to contact

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1. Introduce student to the instructor

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Be clear about your intentions

- Instructors were typically contacted at the start of the academic term by a staff member from the postsecondary education program indicating that a student with ID wished to take their course.
- Unclear if this was a request for approval or only as advance notification.



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What information should be shared?



Student's disability or diagnosis

- Should this be shared?
- Has the student agreed to disclose?
- Who tells them?
- How is this information going to be used?
 - Determine course fit?
 - Identify accommodations?

Best practices for teaching students with particular disabilities

Students' academic goals and needs related to the course topic.

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Examples of communications

- Introductory emails
- Frequently asked questions
- Overview or powerpoint materials
- Videos
- Information on program webpage



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2. Be clear about expectations and grading

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Confusion about Expectations and Grades

"I pretty much allow them to do whatever they want to do in my ... classes, because they don't get graded. I mean if someone turns in a paper, I will grade it and give it back to them. But I don't give them a—they don't get a grade on the computer."

"I don't know if I'm supposed to be requiring them to do more, but ... what I took from the mentor was that ... it's not like grading for regular class. It's sort of allowing the students to participate in the level that they'd feel comfortable and able to participate to make it the most beneficial experience, but I don't know if that's the right philosophy, but that's—that was the philosophy that I took from it"



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Can you predict some questions and have answers ready and accessible?

Western Carolina University University Participant (UP) Program Faculty Frequently Asked Questions (HOPEFULLY coming out of COVID)

Will the UP student in my class receive a letter grade for their performance?

No. UP students are non-degree seeking. In two years at WCU they will only audit courses. They will receive a university validated, meaningful certificate, but successful completion of this certificate is not dependent on grades or a GPA.

Though receiving no grades, the UP students, like all students, depend on your timely feedback to continuously improve. They have individual academic goals and class projects to complete as part of their UP certificate of completion.

Will the UP student in my class take exams, including final exams?

Because UP students audit courses sitting exams is often not required. However, test protocol is usually established between instructor and auditing student. You may request that UP students do or do not sit in your exams.

Final exams are less common. UP students often leave campus on or around the final day of class. Again, if you wish for a UP student to sit in-person at a final exam, please communicate that desire and we will try our best to meet your request.

- Grading expectations
- Instructor's authority to require exams or completion of assignments
- Role of the peer mentor
- Who is the decision maker (student, peer, program staff)
- Appropriate and needed accommodations and modifications



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3. Offer supports to faculty



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I didn't know what that meant to work with a [TPSID] student.

And so I realized that I had to, one, communicate and talk with the [TPSID] office at that time and understand what the program was about and...see what the learning outcomes were for the student. What was the goal that we wanted? Once I realized that I had [TPSID] student, my expectations were--really at that point, I was nervous because...that was not my training.



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"I think a lot of times, especially younger faculty may feel a little bit intimidated not really knowing—this is a little bit different. They don't have a class, as far as I know, in graduate school about how to teach [students with ID]. And so, how do we do that? And so, having a system in place where people are allowed to ask questions is incredibly important"

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Faculty recommendations

- Use experienced instructors to recruit new faculty
- Highlight and share benefits of inclusive courses to reduce feelings of apprehension
- Set up observations of colleague's inclusive class
"to realize that it's not as difficult as you might think"



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Need for ongoing communication and support

- Clarify the role of the peer mentor
- Avoid relying entirely on peer mentors as liaisons
- Ensure instructors know who to talk to with questions
- Help students assume direct communication
- Consider doing a mid-semester check-in
- Offer targeted training prior to and during the semester
- Consider how to share best practices
- Create opportunities to ask program staff and other faculty questions.



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4. Share information about your program with the campus community

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"It wasn't until the end of that first semester that I really started to understand, okay, I get what this program is trying to do now. But there's a pretty big learning curve there that first semester or two."



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Informing the College and University

- Faculty and department meetings
- First year seminar instructors
- Centers for teaching excellence
- New faculty orientation materials
- Open houses



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Orientation Information could address

- “Intellectual Disability 101”
- Program Overview (incl. goals, procedures)
- Expectations (for faculty and for students)
- Teaching practices/Universal Design for Learning
- Assessment and grading guidance
- Information about students
- Educational interests, goals
- Why this class?
- Accommodations needs
- Ideas on making syllabus more accessible /UDL



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Resources

WEBINARS

- Tips from Faculty: Engaging Students with Intellectual Disability Enrolled in College Courses-[webinar](#) and [resource packet](#) by [Shakonda Diggs](#), and [Patrick McDermott](#)
- [How one university does inclusive courses: Strategies and Examples from the University of Kansas](#) by Georgia Campbell and Dana Lattin.

WEBSITE

- UDL on Campus-Universal Design for Learning in Higher Education- <http://udloncampus.cast.org/home>

BOOK (Chapter 7)

- [Teaching, Including, and Supporting College Students with Intellectual Disabilities](#) by Kelly R. Kelley and , David L. Westling

Articles

- Hall, C., McCabe, L., Carter, E., Lee, Ph.D., E., & Bethune-Dix, L. (2021). Teaching College Students with Intellectual Disability: Faculty Experiences with Inclusive Higher Education. *Journal of Inclusive Postsecondary Education*, 3(1). <https://doi.org/10.13021/jipe.2021.2730>
- Taylor, A., Domin, D., Papay, C., & Grigal, M. (2021). “More dynamic, more engaged”: Faculty perspectives on instructing students with intellectual disability in inclusive courses. *Journal of Inclusive Postsecondary Education*, 3(1). <https://doi.org/10.13021/jipe.2021.2924>



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